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Rose

At the church square, Rose hesitated. Nagging doubts buzzed in her mind. Was Josef right that she couldn't handle the Gestapo officer? Should she reconsider and play it safe? Maybe he would forget her and she could just wait out the war. Yet fortune had put her in this unique position—to help others and possibly see André in Berlin—and she would never forgive herself if she didn't seize this chance. She had to try.

It began to rain. Thick, heavy drops signaled a larger storm on its way. Tucking the file inside her coat, she ran across the street to the building with the saddle roof. She opened the door, expecting someone might appear and demand her work card. But the corridor was empty and quiet. The door clicked shut behind her. She removed the file from her coat and reached for the wooden banister.

The treads creaked and the boards bent under her weight. With each step, she felt fear and unease rising within her. It was one thing to meet a Gestapo officer by chance, another thing entirely to seek him out. *You can do this*. Reaching the barren first floor, she guessed everyone had left for the day. She continued until she arrived on the second floor. A door to the left of the stairs stood ajar. She heard the crackling and popping of a fire in a hearth, along with the pungent scent of ash and smoke, drifting into the corridor.

"Herr Kriminalinspektor Reinhardt?" Rose called out, not wishing to startle him.

Clomp, thud. She stiffened at the sound of his jackboots on the wooden floor.

A foreboding figure appeared at the door. "Is that Fräulein Cotillard?